

'Madame de Saint-Remy! Where shall I hide myself?' exclaimed Raoul, catching at the dress of Montalais, who looked quite bewildered.

'Yes,' said she; 'yes, I know the clicking of those pattens! It is our excellent mother. M. le Vicomte, what a pity it is the window looks upon a stone pavement, and that fifty paces below it.'

Raoul glanced at the balcony in despair. Louise seized his arm and held it tight.

'Oh, how silly I am!' said Montalais; 'have I not the robe-of-ceremony closet? It looks as if it were made on purpose.'

It was quite time to act; Madame de Saint-Remy was coming up at a quicker pace than usual. She gained the landing at the moment when Montalais, as in all scenes of surprises, shut the closet by leaning with her back against the door.

'Ah!' cried Madame de Saint-Remy, 'you are here, are you, Louise?'

'Yes, madame,' replied she, more pale than if she had committed a great crime.

'Well, well!'

'Pray be scared, madame,' said Montalais, offering her a chair, which she placed so that the back was towards the closet.

'Thank you, Mademoiselle Aure—thank you. Come, my child, be quick.'

'Where do you wish me to go, madame?'

'Why, home, to be sure; have you not to prepare your toilette?'

'What did you say?' cried Montalais, hastening to affect surprise, so fearful was she that Louise would in some way commit herself.

'You don't know the news, then?' said Madame de Saint-Remy.

'What news, madame, is it possible for two girls to learn up in this dove-cote?'

'What! have you seen nobody?'

'Madame, you talk in enigmas, and you torment us at a slow fire!' cried Montalais, who, terrified at seeing Louise become paler and paler, did not know to what saint to put up her vows.

At length she caught an eloquent look of her companion's, one of those looks which would convey intelligence to a brick wall. Louise directed her attention to a hat—Raoul's unlucky hat, which was set out in all its feathery splendour upon the table.

Montalais sprang towards it, and, seizing it with her left hand, passed it behind her into the right, concealing it as she was speaking.

'Well,' said Madame de Saint-Remy, 'a courier has arrived, announcing the approach of the king. There, mesdemoiselles; there is something to make you put on your best looks.'

'Quick, quick!' cried Montalais. 'Follow Madame your mother, Louise; and leave me to get ready my dress of ceremony.'

Louise arose; her mother took her by the hand, and led her out on to the landing.

'Come along,' said she; then adding in a low voice, 'When I forbid you to come the apartment of Montalais, why do you do so?'

'Madame, she is my friend. Besides, I had but just come.'

'Did you see nobody concealed while you were there?'

'Madame!'

'I saw a man's hat, I tell you—the hat of that fellow, that good-for-nothing!'

'Madame!' repeated Louise.

'Of that do-nothing Malicorne! A maid of honour to have such company—fie! fie!' and their voices were lost in the depths of the narrow staircase.

Montalais had not missed a word of this conversation, which echo conveyed to her as if through a tunnel. She shrugged her shoulders on seeing Raoul, who had listened likewise, issue from the closet.

'Poor Montalais!' said she, 'the victim of friendship! Poor Malicorne, the victim of love!'

She stopped on viewing the tragic-comic face of Raoul, who was vexed at having, in one day, surprised so many secrets.

'Oh, mademoiselle!' said he; 'how can we repay your kindness?'

'Oh, we will balance accounts some day,' said she. 'For the present, begone, M. de Bragelonne, for Madame de Saint-Remy is not over indulgent; and any indiscretion on her part might bring hither a domiciliary visit, which would be disagreeable to all parties.'

'But Louise—how shall I know—'

'Begone! begone! King Louis xi knew very well what he was about when he invented the post.'

'Alas!' sighed Raoul.

'And am I not here—I, who am worth all the posts in the kingdom? Quick, I say, to horse! so that if Madame de Saint-Remy should return for the purpose of preaching me a lesson on morality, she may not find you here.'

'She would tell my father, would she not?' murmured Raoul.

'And you would be scolded. Ah, vicomte, it is very plain you come from court; you are as timid as the king. Pest! at Blois we contrive better than that, to do without papa's consent. Ask Malicorne else!'

And at these words the girl pushed Raoul out of the room by the shoulders. He glided swiftly down to the porch, regained his horse, mounted, and set off as if he had had Monsieur's guards at his heels.

'Louise, you are so extremely reasonable, that you will never know how to love.'

'Oh!' said Louise, in a tone of tender reproach, 'don't you see, Montalais? The queen-mother desires to marry her son to the Infanta: would you wish him to disobey his mother? Is it for a royal heart like his to set such a bad example? When parents forbid love, love must be banished.'

And Louise sighed: Raoul cast down his eyes, with an expression of constraint. Montalais, on her part, laughed aloud.

'Well, I have no parents!' said she.

'You are acquainted, without doubt, with the state of health of M. le Comte de la Fère?' said Louise, after breathing that sigh which had revealed so many griefs in its eloquent utterance.

'No, mademoiselle,' replied Raoul, 'I have not let paid my respects to my father; I was going to his house when Mademoiselle de Montalais so kindly stopped me. I hope the comte is well. You have heard nothing to the contrary, have you?'

'No, M. Raoul—nothing, thank God!'

Here, for several instants, ensued a silence, during which two spirits, which followed the same idea, communicated perfectly, without even the assistance of a single glance.

'Oh, heavens!' exclaimed Montalais in a fright; 'there is somebody coming up.'

'Who can it be?' said Louise, rising in great agitation.

'Mesdemoiselles, I inconvenience you very much. I have, without doubt, been very indiscreet,' stammered Raoul, very ill at ease.

'It is a heavy step,' said Louise.

'Ah! if it is only M. Malicorne,' added Montalais, 'do not disturb yourselves.'

Louise and Raoul looked at each other to inquire who M. Malicorne could be.

'There is no occasion to mind him,' continued Montalais; 'he is not jealous.'

'But, mademoiselle—' said Raoul.

'Yes, I understand. Well, he is discreet as I am.'

'Good heavens!' cried Louise, who had applied her ear to the door, which had been left ajar; 'it is my mother's step!'

‘They would be very difficult to please,’ replied Raoul, faithful to his regular system of gallantry.

‘Thank you, Monsieur le Vicomte. We were saying, then, that the king is coming to Blois?’

‘With all the court.’

‘Mesdemoiselles de Mancini, will they be with them?’

‘No, certainly not.’

‘But as the king, it is said, cannot do without Mademoiselle Mary?’

‘Mademoiselle, the king must do without her. M. le Cardinal will have it so. He has exiled his nieces to Brouage.’

‘He!—the hypocrite!’

‘Hush!’ said Louise, pressing a finger on her friend’s rosy lips.

‘Bah! nobody can hear me. I say that old Mazarino Mazarini is a hypocrite, who burns impatiently to make his niece Queen of France.’

‘That cannot be, mademoiselle, since M. le Cardinal, on the contrary, had brought about the marriage of his majesty with the Infanta Maria Theresa.’

Montalais looked Raoul full in the face, and said, ‘And do you Parisians believe in these tales? Well! we are a little more knowing than you, at Blois.’

‘Mademoiselle, if the king goes beyond Poitiers and sets out for Spain; if the articles of the marriage contract are agreed upon by Don Luis de Haro and his eminence, you must plainly perceive that it is not child’s play.’

‘All very fine! but the king is king, I suppose?’

‘No doubt, mademoiselle; but the cardinal is the cardinal.’

‘The king is not a man, then! And he does not love Mary Mancini?’

‘He adores her.’

‘Well, he will marry her then. We shall have war with Spain. M. Mazarin will spend a few of the millions he has put away; our gentlemen will perform prodigies of valour in their encounters with the proud Castilians, and many of them will return crowned with laurels, to be recrowned by us with myrtles. Now, that is my view of politics.’

‘Montalais, you are wild!’ said Louise, ‘and every exaggeration attracts you as light does a moth.’

Chapter IV Father and Son



AOUL followed the well-known road, so dear to his memory, which led from Blois to the residence of the Comte de la Fère.

The reader will dispense with a second description of that habitation: he, perhaps, has been with us there before, and knows it. Only, since our last journey thither, the walls had taken on a grayer tint, and the brick-work assumed a more harmonious copper tone; the trees had grown, and many that then only stretched their slender branches along the tops of the hedges, now, bushy, strong, and luxuriant, cast around, beneath boughs swollen with sap, great shadows of blossoms or fruit for the benefit of the traveller.

Raoul perceived, from a distance, the two little turrets, the dove-cote in the elms, and the flights of pigeons, which wheeled incessantly around that brick cone, seemingly without power to quit it, like the sweet memories which hover round a spirit at peace.

As he approached, he heard the noise of the pulleys which grated under the weight of the heavy pails; he also fancied he heard the melancholy moaning of the water which falls back again into the wells—a sad, funeral, solemn sound, which strikes the ear of the child and the poet—both dreamers—which the English call *splash*; Arabian poets *gagachan*¹; and which we Frenchmen, who would be poets, can only translate by a paraphrase—the noise of water falling into water.

It was more than a year since Raoul had been to visit his father. He had passed the whole time in the household of M. le Prince. In fact,

¹This word is either a transliteration garbled beyond recognition or an invention of Dumas’s.

after all the commotions of the Fronde, of the early period of which we formerly attempted to give a sketch, Louis de Condé had made a public, solemn and frank reconciliation with the court. During all the time that the rupture between the king and the prince had lasted, the prince, who had long entertained a great regard for Bragelonne, had in vain offered him advantages of the most dazzling kind for a young man. The Comte de la Fère, still faithful to his principles of loyalty, and royalty, one day developed before his son in the vaults of Saint Denis,—the Comte de la Fère, in the name of his son, had always declined them. Moreover, instead of following M. de Condé in his rebellion, the vicomte had followed M. de Turenne, fighting for the king. Then when M. de Turenne, in his turn, had appeared to abandon the royal cause, he had quitted M. de Turenne, as he had quitted M. de Condé. It resulted from this invariable line of conduct, that, as Condé and Turenne had never been conquerors of each other but under the standard of the king, Raoul, however young, had ten victories inscribed on his list of services, and not one defeat from which his bravery or conscience had to suffer.

Raoul, therefore, had, in compliance with the wish of his father, served obstinately and passively the fortunes of Louis XIV, in spite of the tergiversations which were endemic, and, it might be said, inevitable, at that period.

A. de Condé, on being restored to favour, had at once availed himself of all the privileges of the amnesty to ask for many things back again which had been granted to him before, and among others, Raoul. M. de la Fère, with his invariable good sense, had immediately sent him again to the prince.

A year, then, had passed away since the separation of the father and son; a few letters had softened, but not removed, the pain of absence. We have seen that Raoul had left at Blois another love in addition to filial love. But let us do him this justice—if it had not been for chance and Mademoiselle de Montalais, two great temptations, Raoul, after delivering his message, would have galloped off towards his father's house, turning his head round, perhaps, but without stopping for a single instant, even if Louise had held out her arms to him.

So the first part of the journey was given by Raoul to regretting the past which he had been forced to quit so quickly, that is to say, his lady-love;

Montalais, maid of honour to her royal highness Madame, and moreover my friend—my excellent friend.'

Raoul bowed ceremoniously.

'And me, Louise,' said he—'will you not present me also to mademoiselle?'

'Oh, she knows you—she knows all!'

This unguarded expression made Montalais laugh and Raoul sigh with happiness, for he interpreted it thus: 'She knows all our love.'

'The ceremonies being over, Monsieur le Vicomte,' said Montalais, 'take a chair, and tell us quickly the news you bring flying thus.'

'Mademoiselle, it is no longer a secret; the king, on his way to Poitiers, will stop at Blois, to visit his royal highness.'

'The king here!' exclaimed Montalais, clapping her hands. 'What! are we going to see the court? Only think, Louise—the real court from Paris! Oh, good heavens! But when will this happen, monsieur?'

'Perhaps this evening, mademoiselle; at latest, to-morrow.'

Montalais lifted her shoulders in a sigh of vexation.

'No time to get ready! No time to prepare a single dress! We are as far behind the fashions as the Poles. We shall look like portraits from the time of Henry IV. Ah, monsieur! this is sad news you bring us!'

'But, mesdemoiselles, you will be still beautiful!'

'That's no news! Yes, we shall always be beautiful, because nature has made us passable; but we shall be ridiculous, because the fashion will have forgotten us. Alas! ridiculous! I shall be thought ridiculous—I!'

'And by whom?' said Louise, innocently.

'By whom? You are a strange girl, my dear. Is that a question to put to me? I mean everybody; I mean the courtiers, the nobles; I mean the king.'

'Pardon me, my good friend; but as here every one is accustomed to see us as we are—'

'Granted; but that is about to change, and we shall be ridiculous, even for Blois; for close to us will be seen the fashions from Paris, and they will perceive that we are in the fashion of Blois! It is enough to make one despair!'

'Console yourself, mademoiselle.'

'Well, so let it be! After all, so much the worse for those who do not find me to their taste!' said Montalais, philosophically.

The girl continued to walk on—he followed her; she entered a chamber—he did the same.

As soon as he was fairly in the net he heard a loud cry, and, turning round, saw at two paces from him, with her hands clasped and her eyes closed, that beautiful fair girl with blue eyes and white shoulders, who, recognizing him, called him Raoul.

He saw her, and divined at once so much love and so much joy in the expression of her countenance, the he sank on his knees in the middle of the chamber, murmuring, on his part, the name of Louise.

‘Ah! Montalais!—Montalais!’ she sighed, ‘it is very wicked to deceive me so.’

‘Who, I? I have deceived you?’

‘Yes, you told me you would go down to inquire the news, and you have brought up monsieur!’

‘Well, I was obliged to do so—how else could he have received the letter you wrote him?’ And she pointed with her finger to the letter which was still upon the table.

Raoul made a step to take it; Louise, more rapid, although she had sprung forward with a sufficiently remarkable physical hesitation, reached out her hand to stop him. Raoul came in contact with that trembling hand, took it within his own, and carried it so respectfully to his lips, that he might have been said to have deposited a sigh upon it rather than a kiss.

In the meantime, Mademoiselle de Montalais had taken the letter, folded it carefully, as women do, in three folds, and slipped it into her bosom.

‘Don’t be afraid, Louise,’ said she; ‘monsieur will no more venture to take it hence than the defunct king Louis XIII ventured to take billets from the corsage of Mademoiselle de Hautefort.’

Raoul blushed at seeing the smile of the two girls; and he did not remark that the hand of Louise remained in his.

‘There!’ said Montalais, ‘you have pardoned me, Louise, for having brought monsieur to you; and you, monsieur, bear me no malice for having followed me to see mademoiselle. Now, then, peace being made, let us chat like old friends. Present me, Louise, to M. de Bragelonne.’

‘Monsieur le Vicomte,’ said Louise, with her quiet grace and ingenuous smile, ‘I have the honour to present to you Mademoiselle Aure de

and the other part to the friend he was about to join, so much too slowly for his wishes.

Raoul found the garden-gate open, and rode straight in, without regarding the long arms, raised in anger, of an old man dressed in a jacket of violet-coloured wool, and a large cap of faded velvet.

The old man, who was weeding with his hands a bed of dwarf roses and marguerites, was indignant at seeing a horse thus traversing his sanded and nicely-raked walks. He even ventured a vigorous ‘Humph!’ which made the cavalier turn round. Then there was a change of scene; for no sooner had he caught sight of Raoul’s face, than the old man sprang up and set off in the direction of the house, amidst interrupted growlings, which appeared to be paroxysms of wild delight.

When arrived at the stables, Raoul gave his horse to a little lackey, and sprang up the perron with an ardour that would have delighted the heart of his father.

He crossed the ante-chamber, the dining-room, and the salon, without meeting any one; at length, on reaching the door of M. de la Fère’s apartment, he rapped impatiently, and entered almost without waiting for the word ‘Enter!’ which was vouchsafed him by a voice at once sweet and serious. The comte was seated at a table covered with papers and books; he was still the noble, handsome gentleman of former days, but time had given to this nobleness and beauty a more solemn and distinct character. A brow white and void of wrinkles, beneath his long hair, now more white than black; an eye piercing and mild, under the lids of a young man; his moustache, fine but slightly grizzled, waved over lips of a pure and delicate model, as if they had never been curled by mortal passions; a form straight and supple; an irreproachable but thin hand—this was what remained of the illustrious gentleman whom so many illustrious mouths had praised under the name of Athos. He was engaged in correcting the pages of a manuscript book, entirely filled by his own hand.

Raoul seized his father by the shoulders, by the neck, as he could, and embraced him so tenderly and so rapidly, that the comte had neither strength nor time to disengage himself, or to overcome his paternal emotions.

‘What! you here, Raoul—you! Is it possible?’ said he.

‘Oh, monsieur, monsieur, what joy to see you once again!’

‘But you don’t answer me, vicomte. Have you leave of absence, or has some misfortune happened at Paris?’

‘Thank God, monsieur,’ replied Raoul, calming himself by degrees, ‘nothing has happened but what is fortunate. The king is going to be married, as I had the honour of informing you in my last letter, and, on his way to Spain, he will pass through Blois.’

‘To pay a visit to Monsieur?’

‘Yes, monsieur le comte. So, fearing to find him unprepared, or wishing to be particularly polite to him, monsieur le prince sent me forward to have the lodgings ready.’

‘You have seen Monsieur?’ asked the comte, eagerly.

‘I have had that honour.’

‘At the castle?’

‘Yes, monsieur,’ replied Raoul, casting down his eyes, because, no doubt, he had felt there was something more than curiosity in the comte’s inquiries.

‘Ah, indeed, vicomte? Accept my compliments thereupon.’

Raoul bowed.

‘But you have seen some one else at Blois?’

‘Monsieur, I saw her royal highness, Madame.’

‘That’s very well: but it is not Madame that I mean.’

Raoul coloured deeply, but made no reply.

‘You do not appear to understand me, monsieur le vicomte,’ persisted M. de la Fère, without accenting his words more strongly, but with a rather severer look.

‘I understand you quite plainly, monsieur,’ replied Raoul, ‘and if I hesitate a little in my reply, you are well assured I am not seeking for a falsehood.’

‘No, you cannot tell a lie; and that makes me so astonished you should be so long in saying yes or no.’

‘I cannot answer you without understanding you very well; and if I have understood you, you will take my first words in ill part. You will displeased, no doubt, monsieur le comte, because I have seen—’

‘Mademoiselle de la Vallière—have you not?’

‘It was of her you meant to speak, I know very well, monsieur,’ said Raoul, with inexpressible sweetness.

Chapter III

The Interview



RAOUL made one step towards the girl who thus called him.

‘But my horse, madame?’ said he.

‘Oh! you are terribly embarrassed! Go yonder way—there is a shed in the outer court: fasten your horse, and return quickly!’

‘I obey, madame.’

Raoul was not four minutes in performing what he had been directed to do; he returned to the little door, where, in the gloom, he found his mysterious conductress waiting for him, on the first steps of a winding staircase.

‘Are you brave enough to follow me, monsieur knight errant?’ asked the girl, laughing at the momentary hesitation Raoul had manifested.

The latter replied by springing up the dark staircase after her. They thus climbed up three stories, he behind her, touching with his hands, when he felt for the banister, a silk dress which rubbed against each side of the staircase. At every false step made by Raoul, his conductress cried, ‘Hush!’ and held out to him a soft perfumed hand.

‘One would mount thus to the belfry of the castle without being conscious of fatigue,’ said Raoul.

‘All of which means, monsieur, that you are very much perplexed, very tired, and very uneasy. But be of good cheer, monsieur; here we are, at our destination.’

The girl threw open a door, which immediately, without any transition, filled with a flood of light the landing of the staircase, at the top of which Raoul appeared, holding fast by the balustrade.

'And I asked you if you have seen her.'

'Monsieur, I was ignorant, when I entered the castle, that Mademoiselle de la Vallière was there; it was only on my return, after I had performed my mission, that chance brought us together. I have had the honour of paying my respects to her.'

'But what do you call the chance that led you into the presence of Mademoiselle de la Vallière?'

'Mademoiselle de Montalais, monsieur.'

'And who is Mademoiselle de Montalais?'

'A young lady I did not know before, whom I had never seen. She is maid of honour to Madame.'

'Monsieur le vicomte, I will push my interrogatory no further, and reproach myself with having carried it so far. I had desired you to avoid Mademoiselle de la Vallière, and not to see her without my permission. Oh, I am quite sure you have told me the truth, and that you took no measures to approach her. Chance has done me this injury; I do not accuse you of it. I will be content, then, with what I formerly said to you concerning this young lady. I do not reproach her with anything—God is my witness! only it is not my intention or wish that you should frequent her place of residence. I beg you once more, my dear Raoul, to understand that.'

It was plain the limpid eyes of Raoul were troubled at this speech.

'Now, my friend,' said the comte, with his soft smile, and in his customary tone, 'let us talk of other matters. You are returning, perhaps, to your duty?'

'No, monsieur, I have no duty for to-day, except the pleasure of remaining with you. The prince kindly appointed me no other: which was so much in accord with my wish.'

'Is the king well?'

'Perfectly.'

'And monsieur le prince also?'

'As usual, monsieur.'

The comte forgot to inquire after Mazarin; that was an old habit.

'Well, Raoul, since you are entirely mine, I will give up my whole day to you. Embrace me—again, again! You are at home, vicomte! Ah, there

is our old Grimaud! Come in, Grimaud: monsieur le vicomte is desirous of embracing you likewise.'

The good old man did not require to be twice told; he rushed in with open arms, Raoul meeting him half-way.

'Now, if you please, we will go into the garden, Raoul. I will show you the new lodging I have had prepared for you during your leave of absence; and whilst examining the last winter's plantations, and two saddle-horses I have just acquired, you will give me all the news of our friends in Paris.'

The comte closed his manuscript, took the young man's arm, and went out into the gardens with him.

Grimaud looked at Raoul with a melancholy air as the young man passed out; observing that his head nearly touched the traverse of the doorway, stroking his white royale, he slowly murmured:—'How he has grown!'



A SOFT VOICE CALLED HIM FROM THE DEPTHS OF AN OBSCURE PATH

all the domestics, with a buzzing like that of several bee-hives, surrounded Raoul for the purpose of questioning him.

Madame saw this movement, and called M. de Saint-Remy.

‘This is not the time for gossiping, but working,’ said she, with the tone of an angry housekeeper.

A. de Saint-Remy hastened to break the circle formed by the officers round Raoul, so that the latter was able to gain the ante-chamber.

‘Care will be taken of that gentleman, I hope,’ added Madame, addressing M. de Saint-Remy.

The worthy man immediately hastened after Raoul. ‘Madame desires refreshments to be offered to you,’ said he; ‘and there is, besides, a lodging for you in the castle.’

‘Thanks, M. de Saint-Remy,’ replied Raoul; ‘but you know how anxious I must be to pay my duty to M. le Comte, my father.’

‘That is true, that is true, Monsieur Raoul; present him, at the same time, my humble respects, if you please.’

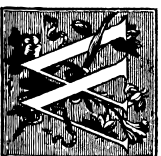
Raoul thus once more got rid of the old gentleman, and pursued his way. As he was passing under the porch, leading his horse by the bridle, a soft voice called him from the depths of an obscure path.

‘Monsieur Raoul!’ said the voice.

The young man turned round, surprised, and saw a dark complexioned girl, who, with a finger on her lip, held out her other hand to him. This young lady was an utter stranger.

Chapter V

In Which Something Will be Said of Cropoli



MUST the Comte de la Fère with Raoul visits the new buildings he has erected, and the new horses he has bought, with the reader’s permission we will lead him back to the city of Blois, and make him a witness of the unaccustomed activity which pervades that city.

It was in the hotels that the surprise of the news brought by Raoul was most sensibly felt.

In fact, the king and the court at Blois, that is to say, a hundred horsemen, ten carriages, two hundred horses, as many lackeys as masters—where was this crowd to be housed? Where were to be lodged all the gentry of the neighbourhood, who would gather in two or three hours after the news had enlarged the circle of its report, like the increasing circumstances produced by a stone thrown into a placid lake?

Blois, as peaceful in the morning, as we have seen, as the calmest lake in the world, at the announcement of the royal arrival, was suddenly filled with the tumult and buzzing of a swarm of bees.

All the servants of the castle, under the inspection of the officers, were sent into the city in quest of provisions, and ten horsemen were dispatched to the preserves of Chambord to seek for game, to the fisheries of Beuvron for fish, and to the gardens of Cheverny for fruits and flowers.

Precious tapestries, and lustres with great gilt chains, were drawn from the cupboards; an army of the poor were engaged in sweeping the courts and washing the stone fronts, whilst their wives went in droves to the meadows beyond the Loire, to gather green boughs and field-flowers. The

whole city, not to be behind in this luxury of cleanliness, assumed its best toilette with the help of brushes, brooms, and water. The gutters of the upper town, swollen by these continued ablutions, became rivers at the bottom of the city, and the pavement, generally very muddy, it must be allowed, took a clean face, and absolutely shone in the friendly rays of the sun.

Next the music was to be provided; drawers were emptied; the shopkeepers did a glorious trade in wax, ribbons, and sword-knots; housekeepers laid in stores of bread, meat, and spices. Already numbers of the citizens whose houses were furnished as if for a siege, having nothing more to do, donned their festive clothes, and directed their course towards the city gate, in order to be the first to signal or see the cortège. They knew very well that the king would not arrive before night, perhaps not before the next morning. Yet what is expectation but a kind of folly, and what is that folly but an excess of hope?

In the lower city, at scarcely a hundred paces from the Castle of the States, between the mall and the castle, in a sufficiently handsome street, then called the Rue Vieille, and which must, in fact, have been very old, stood a venerable edifice, with pointed gables, of squat but large dimensions, ornamented with three windows looking into the street on the first floor, with two in the second, and with a little *œil de boeuf* in the third.

On the sides of this triangle had recently been constructed a parallelogram of considerable size, which encroached upon the street remorselessly, according to the familiar uses of the building of that period. The street was narrowed by a quarter by it, but then the house was enlarged by a half, and was not that a sufficient compensation?

Tradition said that this house with the pointed gables was inhabited, in the time of Henry III, by a councillor of state whom Queen Catherine came, some say to visit, and others to strangle. However that may be, the good lady must have stepped with a circumspect foot over the threshold of this building.

After the councillor had died—whether by strangulation or naturally is of no consequence—the house had been sold, then abandoned, and lastly isolated from the other houses of the street. Towards the middle of the reign of Louis XIII only, an Italian named Cropolì, escaped from the kitchens of the *Marechal d'Ancre*, came and took possession of this house.

‘Much nearer, *monseigneur*; his majesty must by this time have arrived at Meung.’

‘Does the court accompany him?’

‘Yes, *monseigneur*.’

‘A propos, I forgot to ask you after M. le Cardinal.’

‘His eminence appears to enjoy good health, *monseigneur*.’

‘His nieces accompany him, no doubt?’

‘No, *monseigneur*; his eminence has ordered the *Mesdemoiselles de Mancini* to set out for Brouage. They will follow the left bank of the Loire, while the court will come by the right.’

‘What! *Mademoiselle Mary de Mancini* quit the court in that manner?’ asked *Monsieur*, his reserve beginning to diminish.

‘*Mademoiselle Mary de Mancini* in particular,’ replied *Raoul* discreetly.

A fugitive smile, an imperceptible vestige of his ancient spirit of intrigue, shot across the pale face of the prince.

‘Thanks, M. de Bragelonne,’ then said *Monsieur*. ‘You would, perhaps, not be willing to carry M. le Prince the commission with which I would charge you, and that is, that his messenger has been very agreeable to me; but I will tell him so myself.’

Raoul bowed his thanks to *Monsieur* for the honour he had done him.

Monsieur made a sign to *Madame*, who struck a bell which was placed at her right hand; M. de Saint-Remy entered, and the room was soon filled with people.

‘*Messieurs*,’ said the prince, ‘his majesty is about to pay me the honour of passing a day at Blois; I depend on the king, my nephew, not having to repent of the favour he does my house.’

‘*Vive le Roi!*’ cried all the officers of the household with frantic enthusiasm, and M. de Saint-Remy louder than the rest.

Gaston hung down his head with evident chagrin. He had all his life been obliged to hear, or rather to undergo, this cry of ‘*Vive le Roi!*’ which passed over him. For a long time, being unaccustomed to hear it, his ear had had rest, and now a younger, more vivacious, and more brilliant royalty rose up before him, like a new and more painful provocation.

Madame perfectly understood the sufferings of that timid, gloomy heart; she rose from the table, *Monsieur* irritated her mechanically, and